

Partial Neutralisation of Word-Final Plosives in Colloquial Singapore English

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Overview

Singapore English (SgE), particularly Colloquial Singapore English (CSE) (Leimgruber, 2011), sometimes referred to as Singlish, has attracted linguistic interest due to its distinct phonological features, including lexical stress shifts, intonation patterns, and vowel mergers (Deterding, & Hvitfeldt, 1994). One notable feature is the high rate of word-final /t/ and /d/ deletion (Starr, 2019), alongside other processes such as neutralization (Chow, & Kharlamov, 2018), voicing assimilation, and glottalization (Keays, 2011). More broadly, neutralization in CSE often affects word-final plosives, partially merging voiceless and voiced pairs (e.g., /t/ and /d/) into glottal stops or voicing assimilated variants. The phonological modifications of word-final plosives in CSE generally follow three main patterns:

1. Deletion: Word-final plosive is omitted, as in -t/d deletion (e.g., weekend [wikend] → [wiken]). In line with previous studies, this excludes “n’t” contractions such as in “doesn’t” (Starr, 2019).
2. Glottalization: Word-final plosive is realized as a glottal stop (e.g., week [wik] → [wiʔ]). Some studies reveal glottalization in syllable-final plosives in SgE as well (Keays, 2011).
3. Voicing assimilation: Voiceless and voiced plosives merge, allowing variation in realization (e.g., peek [pik] → [pig]), causing them to match the voicing of adjacent phonemes (Anttila et al., 2008).

Origins

The development of SgE is rooted in Singapore’s colonial history and its cultural diversity (Luo, 2025), based on British English alongside significant Malay and Chinese language influences (Ng, 2011). The absence of consonant clusters in many Chinese dialects has contributed to cluster reduction in SgE. For example, Cantonese, the third most spoken Chinese dialect in Singapore (Sugianto, 2022), only uses six final consonants ([p], [t], [k], [m], [n], and [ŋ]) (EdUHK, n.d.), leading to the neutralization of voiced and voiceless plosives. Similarly, Hokkien (Jordan, 2023), Singapore’s most widely spoken Chinese dialect, features glottal stops as final consonants, which may have influenced the glottalization of word-final plosives, particularly in consonant clusters. Malay influence also plays a role, as Malay speakers of English tend to neutralize final stop voicing contrasts (Shahidi et al., 2012), contributing to similar patterns in SgE.

The distinction between Singlish and Standard Singapore English (SSE) became more pronounced following the launch of the Speak Good English Movement amidst Singapore’s bilingual education policies (Babcock, 2020). While SSE aligns grammatically with other

standard varieties of English worldwide, its phonology still retains vowel mergers and some word-final deletions from CSE. This essay focuses on phonological features observed in CSE.

Examples

Examples of the -t/d deletion and glottalization can be seen in Singapore media.

1. Put my supervisor right
[pu mai supəvaɪzə rai]
“Is putting down my supervisor’s name right?”
“Who in the office would you pick as your emergency contact?”, The Smart Local, 23 March 2025: <https://vt.tiktok.com/ZSrdPRGta/>

The deletion of final consonants in “put” and “right” is realized as [pu] and [rai] (Note that the /ʊ/ monophthong is realized as /u/ in SgE due to vowel mergers). The deletion of plosives extends beyond bilabial plosives to velar plosives, as seen in the realization of “think” as [θiŋ], showing how word-final consonant clusters may also undergo deletion of final plosive. The same video also features glottalization of the /k/ plosive.

2. He just came back
[hi dʒʌs keɪm bɛʔ]
“He just returned”
“Who in the office would you pick as your emergency contact?”, The Smart Local, 23 March 2025: <https://vt.tiktok.com/ZSrdPRGta/>

“back” is realized as [bɛʔ] suggesting that glottalization may be preferred over deletion in SgE if the deletion of the consonant could lead to ambiguity. In this case, a deletion of the [k] allophone would result in [bɛ], potentially causing a loss in meaning. The rate of glottalization and voicing assimilation can be seen to increase with the rate of speech.

3. Swap hands
[swɒb hɛns]
“Swap the items in your hands”
“Lick the lollipop, sniff the soap”, The Smart Local, 16 March 2025: <https://vt.tiktok.com/ZSrdfTWdE/>

The word “swap” is realized as [swɒb], yet the meaning remains clear within the given context. This partial neutralisation between plosives /p/ and /b/ is common in CSE, even when it results in a different word, especially when the meaning can be approximated contextually.

4. Lick the lollipop. Sniff the soap.
[lɪɡ də ɒlɪpɒb snɪf də sɒb]
“Lick the lollipop. Sniff the soap”
“Lick the lollipop, sniff the soap”, The Smart Local, 16 March 2025: <https://vt.tiktok.com/ZSrdfTWdE/>

Similarly, the word-final consonant /p/ in “soap” and lollipop” is often neutralized and approximated to [b] due to voicing assimilation, with the voiceless [p] becoming voiced as [b] due to the preceding voiced vowel. This assimilation did not result in any word does not

typically lead to misunderstanding as semantic context compensates for phonological variation. In addition, word-final obstruents in SgE are incompletely neutralized, with variations in vowel length which allow recovery of the original underlying voicing (Chow, & Kharlamov, 2018).

Usage

The frequency of phonological processes affecting word-final plosives varies across contexts. Consistent with prior research, SgE speakers exhibit a notably high rate of -t/d deletion at up to 85% (Starr, 2019), especially when the plosive precedes another consonant. Mohanan proposed a rule ordering for consonant cluster simplification in SgE in the order of voicing assimilation, epenthesis, metathesis, deletion, and degemination (Mohanan, 1992). This framework suggests that SgE speakers generally favour deletion over voicing assimilation. Anttila's assertion that voicing assimilation occurs post-lexically further supports the preference for deletion, as it would logically precede assimilation (Anttila, 2006). However, the available data suggest that voicing assimilation, particularly partial neutralization of plosives (Chow, & Kharlamov, 2018), occurs more frequently when a vowel precedes the consonant, aligning with existing literature. Additionally, glottalization appears to be preferred over deletion for -k/g, possibly due to articulatory ease for SgE speakers (Deterding, & Hvitfeldt, 1994).

These phonological processes are characteristic of CSE but may also occur in SSE. The relationship between CSE and SSE have been frequently described as “diglossia” with SSE used in more formal settings (Gupta, 2008), and CSE in more casual conversations (Leimgruber, 2011). The glottalization and of voicing assimilation of final plosives are frequently observed in both CSE and SSE (Tan, n.d.). However, Singaporeans' acute awareness of CSE being nonstandard and local (Starr, 2019) has led to Singapore's education system to emphasize the pronunciation of word-final -t/d (Deterding, 2006). For SSE, this results in a much lower deletion rate in formal contexts.

The study of SgE remains relatively recent, with the International Corpus of English Singapore only added in 2002 (Nelson, 2002). Tracking these phonological changes over time in the last 20 years have been challenging, though the Corpus of Singapore English Messages provides insight into digital SgE usage despite its limitations (Gonzales et al., 2021). While CSE's vocabulary has evolved to incorporate more Hokkien than Malay words (likely due to Singapore's predominantly Chinese demographic) (Nair, 2019), its phonological features particularly, word-final plosive neutralisation and deletion remain consistent. As demonstrated through the previously mentioned media examples and prior research, the persistence of these phonological processes highlights the stability of CSE's unique features over the years.

Conclusion

The phonological characteristics of CSE, particularly the partial neutralization of word-final plosives through deletion, glottalization, and voicing assimilation, highlight its distinct evolution influenced by Singapore's multilingual population. While CSE remains widely used in informal settings, its interaction with SSE in a diglossic context ensures that these phonological processes are context dependent.

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